

There are, as I read the history, two main strands in the rope, apart from that which Zarathushtra himself supplies. One of these will form the subject of inquiry when we have examined the history and teaching of the Prophet himself; for it seems fairly certain that it was outside his own knowledge, though in existence before his time. The work of the Magi, as we shall see, was to build on Zarathushtra's foundation a superstructure which (to put it very moderately) was not in all respects after Zarathushtra's style. The question before us now is the religious position of the people to whom he came. What were the beliefs which he inherited, which he had to accept, to adapt, or to reject? Our evidence for this inquiry will be of very varied character. We examine by the comparative method the prehistoric conditions of the Aryan-speaking tribes before their division into Indian and Iranian as indicated in Lecture I. We pursue our researches into the period of the Achæmenian kings in Persia, and from their monuments and the works of the Greek historians, especially Herodotus, we try to picture the religion of the court and of the people.

The first question which should be settled is that concerning the religion of the early Achæmenian kings. The debate on this famous problem is perhaps not likely to be closed with any decisiveness, the data being curiously ambiguous. I cannot present the material here, but it is really unnecessary, as it has been done so well by experts who (for once) do not require us to go outside English. Indeed, there is a penny pamphlet by Bishop Casartelli which supplies all the quotations that are really germane to the

subject, with the comments of a scholar who carries the utmost weight.¹ Of a more technical character is the very full discussion by Prof. Williams Jackson and Dr L. H. Gray.² Dr Gray gives us a careful summary in his excellent article on the Achæmenians.³ With researches of outstanding importance available for every reader, I may content myself with merely stating my own view and offering a few comments.

We begin with Cyrus. His position might seem to be removed from the range of discussion by the summary dictum of Prof. Eduard Meyer that "it cannot be doubted by any unprejudiced mind that Cyrus was a Zoroastrian."⁴ It will be seen from his words quoted below that this is mainly an inference from the Zoroastrianism of Darius, which Meyer asserts is patent from every word of his Inscription. The specialists are by no means so clear about Darius, and in the case of Cyrus it is hardly too much to say that the "prejudice" which Meyer's dictum implies in any who question it seems to have afflicted them with distressing uniformity. Dr L. H. Gray remarks that "there is no evidence whatever to show that he was a Zoroastrian." Dr Casartelli records the doubt whether Cyrus was an "Auramazdean" like Darius, since—

The Assyrian cuneiform inscriptions of that famous conqueror portray him rather as a polytheist, inasmuch as he proclaims himself to the Babylonians the servant and

¹ *The Religion of the Great Kings* (Catholic Truth Society).

² *Journal of the American Oriental Society*, xxi. (1901), p. 164-184.

³ *ERE*, i. 69-72 (1908).

⁴ *Enc. Brit.*, xxi. 205 : cf. *Gesch. d. Alt.*, iii. 21 (" . . . wird, wer die Sachlage besonnen überlegt, nicht bezweifeln; sonst müsste die Religion bei Darius als Neuerung auftreten").

the worshipper of the Assyrio-Babylonian gods. . . . This—it may at least be supposed—was done in order to please his new subjects, and to gain the favour of the powerful sacerdotal body.

That Meyer's *ipse dixit* in itself would be accepted more readily than almost anyone's is undeniable, and in questioning it here I am rather denying than yielding to a "prejudice." We have nothing whatever from Cyrus's own hand which could possibly bear on the question, except the "Cylinder Inscription" with its profession of loyalty to Marduk, and the rescript in Ezra (1^{2,3}) where he declares that Yahweh is God. I do not draw the conclusion that Cyrus was a polytheist, for Darius, the fervent worshipper of Mazdah, makes the like concessions to his foreign subjects; but they will hardly be claimed as evidence that he really adored only the deity who is *not* mentioned! Of course, in the absence of Old Persian inscriptions from him,¹ the silence about Mazdah is intelligible enough. But it will not do for us to compensate for the silence by a mere "doubtless," which is all too often the cloak for a total absence of evidence. We have in fact only two sources of information to eke out Meyer's not very conclusive argument about the improbability that Darius was an innovator. We turn naturally to the Cylinder for what it may give us, which certainly is very little indeed.² The one conspicuous point we

¹ The Murghab inscription ("I am Cyrus the King, the Achæmenian") will not help us—even if it were quite certain that it does not belong to Cyrus the Younger, who might be *kyrabya* in the same sense as Darius's ancestors had the title.

² C. J. Ball, *Light from the East*, p. 224 f., translates the inscription. A microscopic criticism might note that Cyrus is

observe is the relation in which the great king stands to Marduk of Babylon. The theory of local divinities could not be more emphatically stated. Marduk is angry because Nabonidus, anxious to make Marduk supreme, had removed the shrines and images of the local deities to Babylon, which was his own locality. They in turn are angry at being removed away from their own place. So Cyrus, restoring all to their homes, and establishing Marduk as lord in Babylon, supreme because Babylon itself had such primacy, enjoys the favour of all the gods alike.

Dr Gray seeks for material in the *Cyropædia* of Xenophon, and very acutely points out¹ that its subtle coincidences with our Iranian evidence make its testimony much less negligible than it is usually supposed to be. I think he makes a strong case, but that he has omitted to show how Xenophon bridged the gulf of a century and a half between Cyrus and his own Persian travels. When, on the strength of Xenophon's evidence, which Dr Gray thinks the most reliable we have, the religion of Cyrus is inferred to be nearest to that set forth in the Later Avesta, we note the proof as striking and helpful, but for the religion of Artaxerxes Mnemon rather than that of Cyrus. If we regard Cyrus as probably a Mazdean—not a Zoroastrian, however—it will be because Ahura Mazda was “god of the Aryans” (p. 32), and Cyrus belonged to an eminently Aryan clan. If it

again and again “King of the Four Regions” (N., S., E., W.), which is an obvious contrast to the Seven Karšvars of the Later Avestan. But of course Cyrus (or his Babylonian secretary) uses the idioms as well as the language of Babylon.

¹ *ERE*, i. 70.

was possible to be a Mazdean without ever having heard of Zarathushtra, we have nothing left as proof, and next to nothing amounting to a presumption, that Cyrus had come in contact with the Reform. His creed was more probably the popular Iranian nature-worship described so accurately by Herodotus in the *locus classicus* we shall be taking up presently. In many particulars its elemental worship would agree sufficiently with Babylonian and Elamite; and "the God of heaven" in the Ezra rescript suits his own religious phraseology perfectly, especially if his chief god was *Diyauš*, the sky.¹ Since he and his ancestors ruled in a country which was not Iranian, we naturally expect to find non-Aryan traits in any account of him and his ideas.

One solitary scrap of evidence in favour of Cyrus's connexion with Zoroastrianism I am bound to present before I leave him, and I believe the point—*valeat quantum!*—is new. He called his daughter Atossa, which is identified with the Avestan *Hutaosâ*. This was the name of Vishtaspa's queen; and of course the name of Vishtaspa himself, Zarathushtra's royal patron, was perpetuated in the Achæmenian family, in Hystaspes the father of Darius. I do not think the double coincidence can be accidental. How much does it prove? We will return to this when we come to Darius, from whom we are detained for a moment by the intervention of Cambyses. It seems almost grotesque to discuss the religion of one whom only the accident of birth and time rescued from segregation as a criminal lunatic. But maniac though he was, we should expect him to be restrained by

¹ On this see below, pp. 60 i 391 f.

superstition; and it is therefore significant that he had no fear of the wrath of the sacred element when he burnt the corpse of Amasis.¹ This fact may be put with similar notes from the life of Xerxes, and with the well-known argument from the burial of the Achæmenian kings, to show that the Magi had not yet come upon the scene: for all this see p. 215 f. The other fact about Cambyses' religion is the Egyptian text, quoted by Dr Gray, which shows him worshipping the goddess Neit at Sais, as Darius did after him. He acted presumably from a very real fear of the possible consequences of offending the local gods in foreign countries, where *omne ignotum pro magnifico* probably counted more heavily than the politic motives which preponderated with statesmen like Cyrus and Darius.

Before we pass on to consider the religion of Darius, a man for whom religion was obviously a very real experience, we may look into some questions concerning the Achæmenians in general. I quoted just now what seems to be Prof. E. Meyer's one reason for regarding Cyrus as a Zoroastrian—his unwillingness to make Darius an innovator. It is important, therefore, to notice considerations leading us to postulate a rather marked difference between the two branches of the *Haxāmanišiya* clan. Cyrus was king in Elam, while Darius expressly claims that his ancestors were "royal" from Achæmenes down, and possessed "this kingdom which Gaumāta the Magian took from Cambyses . . . both Persia and Media and the other provinces" (*Bh* i. 12). Media at any rate was not ruled by Achæmenians before Cyrus; but Persia

¹ Herodotus, iii. 16.

may well have been. Cyrus reigned over a people among whom Aryans were at best a small minority,¹ but his own Aryan descent² is emphatically endorsed by the statement of Darius that he was "of our family" (*Bh* i. 10), that is, the Achæmenian. According to the Assyrian inscription of Cyrus, he was son of "King Cambyses of the city Ansan," who was son of Cyrus, son of Teispes, both also Kings of Ansan. This makes Hystaspes, Darius's father, third cousin to Cyrus, Teispes (*Caišpiš*) being a common ancestor. If we are to take Darius literally, we can make him "ninth" in royalty by counting the royal line of Ansan from Achæmenes to Cyrus, fifth in succession, and then adding the (younger?) branch Ariaramnes, Arsames, Hystaspes, Darius. The difficulty is that neither Hystaspes nor his father and grandfather are ever called kings. If they exercised any kind of royalty, it must have been in some other province, such as Parthia, where Hystaspes wins a victory for Darius in *Bh* ii. 16. It may be noticed that Darius

¹ Compare E. Meyer's statement (*Enc. Brit.*¹¹, xxi. 203) that the kings of the Mitanni on the Euphrates bore Iranian names, but ruled over people speaking non-Iranian language. Meyer, by the way, makes the Medes Iranian: they reached W. Iran before 900 B.C.

² The names *Kūruš* and *Kambūjiya* are of disputed etymology, but there is no reason whatever to doubt their being Aryan. I do not think there has been any suggestion more attractive than that made long ago by Spiegel (*Altpers. Keilinsch.*², 96) that they attach themselves to Skt *Kuru* and *Kamboja*, originally Aryan heroes of fable, whose names were naturally revived in a royal house. Spiegel thinks that the myths about Cyrus may have originated in confusion between the historical and the mythical heroes. (*Kamboja* is a geographical name, and so is *Kuru* often: hence their appearance in Iranian similarly to-day as *Kur* and *Kamoj*.)

does not say his ancestors were "Great Kings" like himself, or the ancestors of Cyrus in the latter's inscription above referred to (quoted from Spiegel, *op. cit.* 84). A more local sovereignty will satisfy his words.

Suppose, then, that Darius's branch of the family were chieftains in Parthia, where Hystaspes is found after his son had won the supreme throne. We remember, of course, that Herodotus tells us that he was ὑπαρχος in Persia. If we had to choose between Herodotus and the Behistan record, the Greek historian must naturally yield. But there is no real difficulty, for when Darius was once on the throne his satraps could be moved very easily, and he would naturally wish to have his father nearer to his own court. But when it was a matter of quelling a serious rebellion, probably among the subject population, there would be obvious advantages in sending Hystaspes to a country over which he and his ancestors had ruled. On this conjecture, then, Parthia becomes an earlier settlement of the conquering Aryan invaders, from which a prince of the Achæmenian house, Cyrus's ancestor, went on to conquer Elam.

Now Parthia is exactly the district in which we should expect to find the earliest traces of Zoroastrianism proper. Lying east of "Zoroastrian Ragha," on the way towards Bactria, it suits equally well both the possible theories of Zarathushtra's sphere of teaching. He or his successors must have preached to the Parthians as soon as the Religion began to extend beyond its original home, whichever of the two centres may claim it. And this brings us to the remarkable coincidence noted above, in the recurrence

of the names of Vishtaspa and his queen Hutaosa in the father of Darius and the daughter of Cyrus. Antiquity even tended to confuse the two royal Vishtaspas, which may be taken as a slight indication that the name was not common. The repetition of this very significant name in the family of a monarch whose Zoroastrian faith is attested by many lines of evidence, as we shall show, is by itself suggestive. But of course, if Vishtaspa's name is significant for Darius's branch of the Achæmenians, Hutaosa's must be equally significant for that of Cyrus. The names must at least prove, I think, that the memory of the great king was kept alive in both branches of the family; nor is it unlikely that it was cherished on religious as well as on secular grounds. But when we remember how quickly after Zarathushtra's time all but the most superficial features of his teaching were practically lost, and only rediscovered in an esoteric circle by the preservation of the Gathas in worship—a subject which will come before us in Lecture III.—we realise that to prove Cyrus a Zoroastrian in any effective sense demands evidence that his ancestors had maintained the traditional lore in a country where the religion of the people was wholly alien in spirit, and in the face of a powerful tendency, observable in all the metrical Later Avesta itself, to fall back upon the old Iranian nature-worship. As a great champion of Mazdah-worship Vishtaspa might well be commemorated in Cyrus's family; but there is complete absence of proof that for Cyrus his name signified more than this, which we have seen to be on other grounds very probable.

This brings us to ask what tests we should apply to determine the presence of elements due to Zarathushtra's Reform. We saw in the last Lecture that the worship of Ahura Mazda must be abandoned for this purpose, however reluctantly, since there is conclusive reason to believe that he was adored in a tribe which could contribute to the Assyrian pantheon centuries before the earliest possible epoch for Zarathushtra's mission. The sacrifice of this test is a most serious complication in our problem, and may even preclude the possibility of any really decisive solution. But in the case of Darius we have really strong evidence to support the conclusion of Prof. Geldner that "Darius and his successors were without doubt devoted adherents of Zoroastrianism."¹ Meyer's difficulty as to a religious innovation is met by E. W. West's proof that Darius probably reformed the Calendar in a Zoroastrian direction; see *SBE*, xlvii. pp. xliii-xlvii. That Darius was a fervent worshipper of Auramazda may not prove Zarathushtra's influence, but it is of course consistent with it. But what of his failure to mention Zarathushtra himself, Angra Mainyu, and the Amesha Spenta? The first omission is intelligible enough, if the Prophet was a figure of the distant past, but not yet elevated (by Magian theology) into a supernatural being. Taking the Gathas as generally representative of Darius's religion, we might fairly say that the omission is no stranger than that of Paul's name would be in a historical rescript by some pious medieval king, perpetually ascribing his triumphs to the grace of "God and Our Lady," but silent about the Apostles, to whose writings he would of course

¹ *Enc. Brit.*, s.v. "Zoroaster."

attribute the whole of his religious belief.¹ As to the absence of Angra Mainyu, the usual answer is probably sufficient, that the spirit of Zarathushtra's doctrine is adequately reproduced by the frequent mention of "the Lie" (*drauga*), which appears in the Avesta as *draoga*, and (in a different flexion) as *Druj*. Now, as we shall see later on, it is actually not true that Angra Mainyu was Zarathushtra's name for the Evil Spirit. The combination only occurs once in the Gathas (*Ys* 45², see pp. 135 f., 370), and it is there no more a proper name than is the corresponding English when Milton calls Satan "Enemy of God and man." The name for the Evil Spirit in the Gathas is nearly twenty times *Druj*, "the Lie." I point out (below, p. 136) that the Later Avestan transference of this casual appellation, which thus became a proper name, is really the work of the Magi, and very possibly depends upon an association of the two words "enemy" and "liar," which actually occurs in Darius's inscription. That being so, we can see that the king's language is most remarkably in accord with the

¹ My parallel does not convince Dr Casartelli, who writes (May 4, 1913): "Don't you think the omission of Z.'s name in the Royal Inscription a much more extraordinary one than that of Paul (or Peter for the matter of that) in a medieval text? Would it not be nearer to the entire omission of the name of Buddha in Asoka's Inscriptions, or of Mohammed in Islamitic ones?" I must naturally lay some weight on my doctrine that in Darius's day the more abstruse features of Zarathushtra's teaching—such as his personal relation to his followers at the Last Day—had been dimmed by time. And the practical apotheosis of the Prophet, which seems necessary for Dr Casartelli's comparisons, was on my theory entirely the work of the Magi, and later than Darius. Nor is Zarathushtra's absence more remarkable than it is in the Haptanghaiti, if we take the one occurrence as a later addition.